

No Holds Barred

Technology now helps the visually-challenged hear things they can't see

Samir Makwana

Today, if you ask a visually-challenged person conversant with computers about Braille or Talking Libraries, don't be surprised if he says "They're so last decade!" Technology has broadened their horizons. What follows is about what it's like right now... what's happening in India, and what people are doing.

They Aren't Sitting Idle

Shanti Raghavan, founder and managing trustee, Enable India (a charitable trust that helps people with disabilities), avers, "Technology has proved to be a boon for visually-challenged people. It's due to technology that these individuals are now able to pursue education, entertainment, and, most importantly, employment, to make their lives better and more meaningful."

(The term "visually-challenged" refers to those who have entirely lost their sight as well as those with very poor vision.)

In 2002-03, Krishnakant Mane became India's first visually-challenged IT engineer. Inspired by friends with engineering backgrounds, he started off on GNU / Linux, and began promoting the *Free as in*

Freedom philosophy. Today, Mane is a free software developer, teacher, and activist who works with Dr Nagarjuna, computer head at Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education, Mumbai. Mane is currently co-developing Orca, a free screen-reading software for GNU/Linux meant for the visually-challenged.

Jyotindra Mehta is known amongst his peers for his proficiency in IBM Mainframe technology. He currently works with IBM Global Services India as Advisory Software Engineer. Born blind, Mehta is India's first software programmer to have been awarded the Shell Helen Keller Award (in 2004) by the National Centre for Promotion of Employment of Disabled Persons.

Raghavan goes on to say—with no mention of names, though—"A shy group of three people with limited knowledge of the world are now working in the challenging field of medical transcription. It requires perfection—being very careful with spelling—which they mastered in the face of several challenges."

There are many other visually-challenged individuals who have learnt to earn their living with the help of technology. The dynamism of their talent has taken them beyond basic data entry work or writing code to software development and even troubleshooting.

Getting Them Up To Speed

Screen readers, text-to-speech software, and other things which we'll soon mention, are crucial aids: they enable differently-abled people to perform various tasks, by helping them learn how to use technology for education, their main occupation, and of course, entertainment. They are, in short, intended to make them independent.

In the last decade and a half, screen readers, screen magnifiers, text-to-speech software, and Optical Character Recognition (OCR) software has evolved to a great degree. These aids, along with text-to-speech software, audio / MP3 players, audio book readers, and more have fuelled the hunger for knowledge in visually-impaired people.

A number of cyber-café's, Government-supported training centres, and NGOs

